(shh, don't tell Sanghera about the sozzled Safavids, alcoholic Arabs, and tippling Turks). Worse, Brexity Brits betrayed an 'imperial distrust of cleverness' in electing Boris. For colonial officials, Sanghera explains, tended to be 'reliable rather than bright'. Presumably he has in mind such dunces as James Mill and John Maynard Keynes, both India Office employees, or that ICS alumnus B.N. Rau, draftsman of our Constitution.

Historian David Veevers' *The Great Defiance*, on the other hand, is a serious work of history that chronicles the barbarity of colonial conquest. The chapters of the New World, especially those on the decimation of the Kalinago and Ossomocomuck natives, will no doubt come as eye-openers to many readers. However, his puerile prose style, honed by binge-watching *RRR* surely, will prove grating. More disturbingly, his 'celebration' of all manner of resistance takes him to some rather dark places. The Dahomians of West Africa, for instance, are lauded for maintaining a monopoly on the local slave trade. An equally crippling defect is the rather dim view Veevers takes of native agency. Even the slaughter of West Africans by other West Africans is blamed on the beastly Brits. For who was it who sold firearms to those unsuspecting child-like natives?

Skip both volumes and read *Empire Building* instead. Not for Rosie Llewellyn-Jones the de rigueur finger-wagging reflex of 'decolonial' historians. Her brilliantly concise and suggestive book is a social and architectural history of the East India Company that begins in 1690, with Job Charnock laying the foundation for what became Calcutta, and concludes with the railways on the eve of the Revolt. Along the way she takes in the construction of not only hill stations, purpose-built to prevent Brits from succumbing to malaria, but also museums, hospitals, and libraries, thrown up to exude state power. It was a tricky business because architects kept dropping like flies. The Company's joyless accountants proved a nuisance, too, blocking every ambitious proposal on some miserly pretext. Here, then, is a convincing portrait of the Raj, in all its mingy glory. ■

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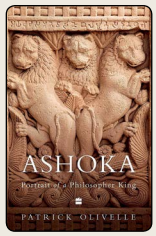
A WRITER'S READS



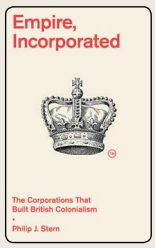
Stranger Than Fiction

Writer and historian **William Dalrymple** found some priceless gems of history writing this year

I hugely enjoyed Patrick Olivelle's beautifully written and utterly compelling new biography, *Ashoka: Portrait of a Philosopher King*. I was intrigued by his speculations about Hellenistic and Seleucid influence at the Mauryan court, and the picture he painted of a cosmopolitan and multicultural Pataliputra. I was also intrigued by Olivelle's ideas about how Ashoka's own conception of dharma may have differed from that of the Buddha. *Ashoka* is a wonderful book and bodes promisingly for Ram Guha's new series of biographies, *Indian Lives*.



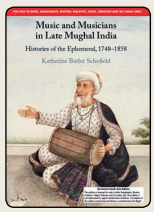
ASHOKA
Portrait of a Philosopher King
By Patrick Olivelle
HARPERCOLLINS
₹799; 400 pages



EMPIRE, INCORPORATED
The Corporations that built British Colonialism
By Philip J. Stern
BELKNAP PRESS
₹699; 408 pages

Empire building is usually envisaged as the concern of nation-states, but as Philip J. Stern convincingly shows in *Empire, Incorporated*, it was initially more often the entirely privatised business of Tudor and Elizabethan commercial corporations. With great clarity and remarkable archival reach, Stern convincingly argues that it was joint-stock 'venture colonialism' that financed and drove the earliest attempts at establishing colonies, blurring the line between commerce and colonialism. It was trading posts, Stern argues, that eventually grew to be the "cornerstone of a British Empire" made up of "charters, concessions and contracts" that "was never fully owned or operated by Britain itself". *Empire, Incorporated* is a remarkable contribution to the current global debate about empire and a small masterpiece of research.

My favourite book of the year is Katherine Butler Schofield's work of historical recreation, *Music and Musicians in Late Mughal India*. In her opening paragraph, Schofield sets out the problem she faces– "How do we write histories of the ephemeral: of emotional and sensory experiences, of ecstatic states and aesthetic journeys, of live performances of music and dance...when those moments have long passed into silence?" With breathtaking research in multiple languages, extraordinary empathy and great literary style and historiographical ambition, she triumphantly answers her own question. This is one of the greatest books on Hindustani music that will change our understanding of both a time and an art.



MUSIC AND MUSICIANS IN LATE MUGHAL INDIA
Histories of the Ephemeral, 1748-1858
By Katherine Butler Schofield
CAMBRIDGE UNIVERSITY PRESS
₹750; 344 pages

as told to Aditya Mani Jha